

The desert is deceiving. At first glance it looks lifeless, barren, and bone-dry. For most passersby humming through the Mojave on their way to try their luck in Las Vegas or heading towards the Grand Canyon, it's just a 26 stretch of land with some mountains in the distance and more 27 to be a setting for a movie that takes place on Mars. The desert, however, is 28 with life, mystery, and magic.

The Mojave desert sees less than two inches of rain a year, and like most deserts, is a land of 29. Temperature fluctuations vary from freezing to 30 hot, not only between seasons, but even within the same day.

At the heart of this vast, 25,000-square-mile desert is Mojave National Preserve. The folks managing and working there wear the wide-brimmed (宽边的) hats that have become 31 with places like Yosemite. The preserve is rich with history, culture, biodiversity, and endless opportunities to 32 your interest, especially for anyone who loves the outdoors. For a photographer, it requires patience and 33 a few spare tires to maneuver the network of unpaved "roads", but the rewards are plenty.

Photographing here requires a good, 34 pair of shoes and a lot of preparation. Plenty of water, spare tires, and a full tank of gas are needed to explore this unit of the national park system, which is the third largest in the country.

Like all deserts, though, if you are patient, you will be rewarded, as they often reveal their secrets slowly. During my last outing, I was surprised to see how much of the area was shaped by ancient volcanoes and geological forces, much of which remains today, giving the area a 35 feel and painting a colorful background for great photographs.

- A) apt
- B) burning
- C) extremes
- D) flat
- E) fractions
- F) overflowing
- G) parasites
- H) probably

- I) sparingly
- J) sprinkle
- K) steer
- L) stimulate
- M) sturdy
- N) synonymous
- O) unique